

SCHOOLS OF BUDDHISM

COMMON BUDDHIST FOUNDATION → TWELVE-LINKED DEPENDENT ORIGATION → MOMENTARINESS AND NO-SELF → KARMA, MEMORY AND NIRVĀṆA → ABHIDHARMA SCHOOL FORK → VAIBHĀṢIKA AND SAUTRĀNTIKA

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure: the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g10 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00 COMMON BUDDHIST FOUNDATION

COMMON BUDDHIST FOUNDATION COMMON THERAPEUTIC CORE DUḤKHA ORIGIN (TRṢNĀ/AVIDYĀ) CESSATION (NIRVĀṆA) EIGHTFOLD PATH THREE MARKS ANĀTMAN DEPENDENT ORIGATION SUPPLIES THE MIDDLE WAY NEITHER ETERNAL SUBSTANCE NOR CAUSELESS ANNIHILATION LATER SCHOOLS DISAGREE

COMMON THERAPEUTIC CORE duḥkha → origin (trṣṇā/avidyā) → cessation (nirvāṇa) → eightfold path three marks

anātman dependent origination supplies the middle way

neither eternal substance nor causeless annihilation later schools disagree about what exists and how it

about the need to end ignorance and craving.

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

COMMON THERAPEUTIC CORE duḥkha → origin (trṣṇā/avidyā) → cessation (nirvāṇa) → eightfold path three marks: anitya

anātman dependent origination supplies the middle way

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

neither eternal substance nor causeless annihilation later schools disagree about what exists and how it is known, not

about the need to end ignorance and craving.

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

COMMON THERAPEUTIC CORE duḥkha → origin (trṣṇā/avidyā) → cessation (nirvāṇa) → eightfold path three marks: anitya

anātman dependent origination supplies the middle way

MECHANISM / VERDICT

Buddhist schools share dependent origination and no-self but disagree over external objects, consciousness and ultimate truth; comparison must therefore preserve both their common therapeutic framework and their distinct ontologies.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE

WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Buddhist schools share dependent origination and no-self but disagree over external objects, consciousness and ultimate truth; comparison must therefore preserve both their common therapeutic framework and their distinct ontologies.

01

STAGE 01 TWELVE-LINKED DEPENDENT ORIGATION

TWELVE-LINKED DEPENDENT ORIGATION IGNORANCE CONDITIONS FORMATIONS; CRAVING AND GRASPING RENEW BECOMING "WHEN THIS IS, THAT COMES TO BE; WITH CESSATION" END AVIDYĀ/TRṢNĀ BREAK APPROPRIATION END REBIRTH-DUḤKHA.

avidyā → saṃskāra → vijñāna → nāma-rūpa → ṣaḍayatana → sparśa

vedanā → trṣṇā → upādāna → bhava → jāti → jarā-marana

IGNORANCE conditions formations; craving and grasping renew becoming

"When this is, that comes to be; with cessation of this, that ceases" reverse order

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

avidyā → saṃskāra → vijñāna → nāma-rūpa → ṣaḍayatana → sparśa

vedanā → trṣṇā → upādāna → bhava → jāti → jarā-marana

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

IGNORANCE conditions formations; craving and grasping renew becoming

"When this is, that comes to be; with cessation of this, that ceases" reverse order: end avidyā/trṣṇā → break appropriation → end rebirth-duḥkha.

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

avidyā → saṃskāra → vijñāna → nāma-rūpa → ṣaḍayatana → sparśa

vedanā → trṣṇā → upādāna → bhava → jāti → jarā-marana

MECHANISM / VERDICT

Recommended opening definition: pratityasamutpāda (dependent origination) is the principle that phenomena arise and cease in dependence on conditions, rejecting both eternalism and causeless annihilationism.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE

WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Recommended opening definition: pratityasamutpāda (dependent origination) is the principle that phenomena arise and cease in dependence on conditions, rejecting both eternalism and causeless annihilationism.

02

STAGE 02 MOMENTARINESS AND NO-SELF

MOMENTARINESS AND NO-SELF CONDITIONED THINGS ARISE AND PERISH KṢĀNIKAVĀDA CAUSAL EFFICACY BELONGS TO THE MOMENT; NO UNCHANGED PERSON ANALYSIS FIVE SKANDHAS RŪPA VIJÑĀNA NONE IS PERMANENT, INDEPENDENT OR "MINE" NAIRĀTMYAVĀDA CONTINUITY CAUSAL SERIES, LIKE FLAME-TO-FLAME; IDENTITY IS NEITHER STRICT SAMENESS

PRATITYASAMUTPĀDA → conditioned things arise and perish → KṢĀNIKAVĀDA causal efficacy belongs to the moment

PERSON ANALYSIS → five skandhas rūpa

vijñāna none is permanent, independent or "mine" → NAIRĀTMYAVĀDA continuity = causal series, like flame-to-flame

identity is neither strict sameness nor total unrelatedness.

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

PRATITYASAMUTPĀDA → conditioned things arise and perish → KṢĀNIKAVĀDA causal efficacy belongs to the moment; no unchanged bearer is required

PERSON ANALYSIS → five skandhas rūpa

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

vijñāna none is permanent, independent or "mine" → NAIRĀTMYAVĀDA continuity = causal series, like flame-to-flame

identity is neither strict sameness nor total unrelatedness.

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

PRATITYASAMUTPĀDA → conditioned things arise and perish → KṢĀNIKAVĀDA causal efficacy belongs to the moment; no unchanged bearer is required

PERSON ANALYSIS → five skandhas rūpa

MECHANISM / VERDICT

Nairātmavāda (no-self doctrine) denies an eternal ātman (self) and explains the person as a dependently ordered continuum of five skandhas (aggregates), preserving conventional identity without a permanent substance.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE

WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Nairātmavāda (no-self doctrine) denies an eternal ātman (self) and explains the person as a dependently ordered continuum of five skandhas (aggregates), preserving conventional identity without a permanent substance.

03

STAGE 03 KARMA, MEMORY AND NIRVĀṆA

KARMA, MEMORY AND NIRVĀṆA NO ĀTMAN, YET CAUSAL RESPONSIBILITY INTENTION AT T1 CONDITIONS STREAM FRUIT AT T2 MEMORY LATER COGNITION CAUSALLY CONDITIONED BY EARLIER EXPERIENCE REBIRTH ONE PSYCHO-PHYSICAL SERIES CONDITIONS ANOTHER, WITHOUT SOUL-TRANSMIGRATION OBJECTION IF AGENT PERISHES, ANOTHER RECEIVES RESULT REPLY SUCCESSOR IS NEITHER IDENTICAL NOR WHOLLY DIFFERENT; CAUSAL APPROPRIATION

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

NO ĀTMAN, YET CAUSAL RESPONSIBILITY intention at t1 → conditions stream → fruit at t2 memory = later

causal appropriation connects nirvāṇa = cessation of greed, hatred and delusion, not destruction of a substance-self.

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

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MECHANISM / VERDICT

NO ĀTMAN, YET CAUSAL RESPONSIBILITY intention at t1 → conditions stream → fruit at t2 memory = later cognition causally conditioned by earlier experience rebirth = one psycho-physical series conditions another, without soul-transmigration objection: if agent perishes, another receives result reply: successor is neither identical nor wholly different; causal appropriation connects nirvāṇa = cessation of greed, hatred and delusion, not destruction of a substance-self.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE

WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: if agent perishes, another receives result reply: successor is neither identical nor wholly different; causal appropriation connects nirvāṇa = cessation of greed, hatred and delusion, not destruction of a substance-self.

04

STAGE 04 ABHIDHARMA SCHOOL FORK

ABHIDHARMA SCHOOL FORK BUDDHIST REALITY KNOWLEDGE DEBATE HINAYĀNA REALISTS MAHĀYĀNA VAIBHĀṢIKA SAUTRĀNTIKA YOGĀCĀRA MĀDHYAMIKA EXTERNAL EXTERNAL OBJECTS COGNITION EMPTINESS SCHOOL LABELS MARK EPISTEMIC/ONTOLOGICAL POSITIONS, NOT FOUR PATHS TO

BUDDHIST REALITY / KNOWLEDGE DEBATE

HINAYĀNA REALISTS MAHĀYĀNA

Vaibhāṣika Sautrāntika Yogācāra Mādhyamika external external objects cognition emptiness of dharmas inferred from ideas only

and causal effects perceived

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

BUDDHIST REALITY / KNOWLEDGE DEBATE

HINAYĀNA REALISTS MAHĀYĀNA

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

Vaibhāṣika Sautrāntika Yogācāra Mādhyamika external external objects cognition emptiness of dharmas inferred from ideas only all svabhāva directly

and causal effects perceived

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

SCHOOL LABELS MARK EPISTEMIC/ONTOLOGICAL POSITIONS, NOT FOUR PATHS TO MIX.

BUDDHIST REALITY / KNOWLEDGE DEBATE

MECHANISM / VERDICT

The four-school debate moves from Vaibhāṣika (Abhidharma realist school) and Sautrāntika (Sūtra-based representationalist school) to Yogācāra (yoga-practice consciousness-centred school) and Mādhyamika (Middle Way emptiness school), progressively questioning what can count as ultimately real.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE

WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The four-school debate moves from Vaibhāṣika (Abhidharma realist school) and Sautrāntika (Sūtra-based representationalist school) to Yogācāra (yoga-practice consciousness-centred school) and Mādhyamika (Middle Way emptiness school), progressively questioning what can count as ultimately real.

05

STAGE 05 VAIBHĀṢIKA AND SAUTRĀNTIKA

VAIBHĀṢIKA AND SAUTRĀNTIKA ISSUE VAIBHĀṢIKA SAUTRĀNTIKA EXTERNAL OBJECT REAL DHARMAS REAL MOMENTARY DHARMAS EXIST ONLY PRESENT CAUSAL MOMENT STRESSED COGNITION GRASPS SAUTRĀNTIKA ARGUMENT OBJECT-MOMENT IS GONE WHEN AWARENESS OCCURS THEREFORE COGNITION PRESENTS AN IMAGE, FROM WHICH EXTERNAL CAUSE REPRESENTATIVE REALISM MUST EXPLAIN CORRESPONDENCE.

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

ISSUE VAIBHĀṢIKA SAUTRĀNTIKA external object real dharmas real momentary causes access direct perception inferred from mental image past/future

sarvāstivāda: dharmas exist only present causal moment stressed cognition grasps object represents object

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

SAUTRĀNTIKA ARGUMENT: object-moment is gone when awareness occurs

therefore cognition presents an image, from which external cause is inferred.

EVALUATION / TRAP

PRESSURE: representative realism must explain correspondence.

ISSUE VAIBHĀṢIKA SAUTRĀNTIKA external object real dharmas real momentary causes access direct perception inferred from mental image past/future

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

ISSUE VAIBHĀṢIKA SAUTRĀNTIKA external object real dharmas real momentary causes access direct perception inferred from mental image past/future

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EVALUATION / TRAP

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ISSUE VAIBHĀṢIKA SAUTRĀNTIKA external object real dharmas real momentary causes access direct perception inferred from mental image past/future

MECHANISM / VERDICT

therefore cognition presents an image, from which external cause is inferred.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE

WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: therefore cognition presents an image, from which external cause is inferred.

06

STAGE 06 YOGĀCĀRA AND MĀDHYAMIKA

YOGĀCĀRA AND MĀDHYAMIKA VIJÑĀNAVĀDA MĀDHYAMIKA ŚŪNYAVĀDA SUBJECT-OBJECT DUALITY IS CONSTRUCTED ALL THINGS LACK SVABHĀVA REPRESENTATION-ONLY DEPENDENT ARISING EMPTINESS ĀLAYA-VIJÑĀNA STORES BĪJA TENDENCIES TWO TRUTHS PARAMĀRTHA THREE NATURES PARIKALPITA, TETRALEMMMA REJECTS IS IS-NOT PARATANTRA, PARINISPAṆNA BOTH

YOGĀCĀRA / VIJÑĀNAVĀDA MĀDHYAMIKA / ŚŪNYAVĀDA subject-object duality is constructed all things lack svabhāva vijñapti-mātra

= emptiness ālaya-vijñāna stores bīja tendencies two truths: saṃvṛti / paramārtha three natures: parikalpita, tetralemma

is-not paratantra, parinispanna both / neither as ultimate capture

CONVERGENCE: dissolve reification

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

YOGĀCĀRA / VIJÑĀNAVĀDA MĀDHYAMIKA / ŚŪNYAVĀDA subject-object duality is constructed all things lack svabhāva vijñapti-mātra: representation-only dependent arising

= emptiness ālaya-vijñāna stores bīja tendencies two truths: saṃvṛti / paramārtha three natures: parikalpita, tetralemma rejects is /

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

is-not paratantra, parinispanna both / neither as ultimate capture

CONVERGENCE: dissolve reification

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

DIFFERENCE: Yogācāra privileges purified cognition, while Mādhyamika empties even consciousness and emptiness itself.

YOGĀCĀRA / VIJÑĀNAVĀDA MĀDHYAMIKA / ŚŪNYAVĀDA subject-object duality is constructed all things lack svabhāva vijñapti-mātra: representation-only dependent arising

MECHANISM / VERDICT

Kṣānikavāda (doctrine of momentariness) holds that whatever is causally efficient exists only momentarily, because a permanent entity could neither change its causal power nor produce genuinely successive effects.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE

WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Kṣānikavāda (doctrine of momentariness) holds that whatever is causally efficient exists only momentarily, because a permanent entity could neither change its causal power nor produce genuinely successive effects.

07

STAGE 07 CRITIQUE AND PYQ ANSWER SPINE

CRITIQUE AND PYQ ANSWER SPINE FLUX CANNOT EXPLAIN CONTINUITY ANĀTMAN WEAKENS AGENCY ŚŪNYATĀ IS NIHILISM CAUSAL SERIES DEPENDENT RESPONSIBILITY EMPTINESS DENIES SELF-NATURE, NOT FUNCTION ANSWER RAIL COMMON CORE

OBJECTIONS: flux cannot explain continuity

anātman weakens agency

Śūnyatā is nihilism

REPLIES: causal series

dependent responsibility

DOCTRINE / CLAIM

OBJECTIONS: flux cannot explain continuity

anātman weakens agency

śūnyatā is nihilism

REPLIES: causal series

OBJECTION / PRESSURE

dependent responsibility

emptiness denies self-nature, not function

ANSWER RAIL common core → twelve links → momentariness → five-skandha no-self

karma/memory reply → four-school fork → exact school comparison

REPLY / RESIDUAL

objection/reply → qualified verdict

CLOSE: Buddhism replaces substance with conditioned process

its schools progressively debate whether external dharmas, cognition, or any intrinsic nature can be retained.

MECHANISM / VERDICT

The central realist criticism is that momentariness and no-self cannot explain recognition, memory and moral responsibility; the Buddhist reply relocates continuity from substance to causally connected santāna (continuum).

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE

WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The central realist criticism is that momentariness and no-self cannot explain recognition, memory and moral responsibility; the Buddhist reply relocates continuity from substance to causally connected santāna (continuum).

E

EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT LAYER-PLACEMENT NOTE LAYER-PLACEMENT NOTE ALL LAYER 3 MATERIAL FROM THE LEGACY IT SHOULD REFINE A CORE ANSWER, NOT DISPLACE THE LAYER 3 - ADVANCED ADVANCED DERIVATION AND SCHOOL DIVERGENCE IT DIAGNOSES THE STRUCTURE OF CONDITIONED BECOMING HERE AND THIS AVOIDS ETERNALISM BECAUSE NO UNCHANGED SELF GROUNDS THE THE DOCTRINE SUPPORTS DIFFERENT ONTOLOGICAL CONCLUSIONS.

OPTIONAL SOURCE WITNESS

Layer-placement note

Layer-placement note All Layer 3 material from the legacy complete session is retained here after practice.

It should refine a core answer, not displace the printed syllabus.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED Advanced derivation and school divergence Dependent origination is not a search for the universe's first cause.

ADVANCED OBJECTION

It diagnoses the structure of conditioned becoming here and now.

This avoids eternalism because no unchanged self grounds the process, and avoids annihilationism because causal continuity remains.

The doctrine supports different ontological conclusions.

Mādhyamika argues that whatever depends on conditions lacks svabhāva and is therefore empty.

COMPARATIVE NUANCE

Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika instead emphasise that causally functioning conditioned events are real.

Their disagreement concerns ultimate status, not whether dependent arising occurs.

The strongest challenge is regress: if every event is conditioned, what explains the chain as a whole?

The Buddhist reply is therapeutic and structural rather than foundational—the task is to identify and cease the conditions

OPTIONAL STATUS

This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.